

# Siblings

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**S**ometimes siblings can fight, and it can be stressful.

**I**t can happen because one feels resentment towards another.

**B**ullying can result if we do not address it.

**L**earning to solve conflicts can be taught from an early age.

**I**gnoring minor struggles can enable them to think for themselves.

**N**ever ignore violence, bullying or destructive behaviours.

**G**uilty of taking sides? We never really know what started it.

**S**upport them to problem solve.



# Problem solving disagreements

## 1. Plan ahead

Talk about this with your children and work out a plan.

Use "when...then..." to set out their plans in a straightforward way. Add visuals to help. Listen to both sides of the story and plan so that both children are happy with the outcome.

Example conversation:



Lizzie – what was the problem?

"Ben shouted at me."

What could you do when Ben shouts?

"I could walk away."

Plan:

When Ben shouts then I will walk away.

Lizzie – why do you think Ben shouted at you?

"I took his game without asking."

What could you do next time?

"I could ask to play."

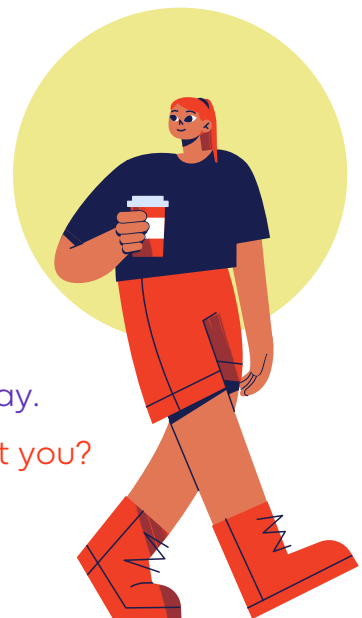
Ask Ben:

Ben what could you do when Lizzie takes something of yours?

"I could say please give it back."

Plan:

When Lizzie takes my things then I will say "Give it back please."



Make a visual of the plan so they can see it and make it simple.

Practice with them so they know what to say/do.

- This is unlikely to work perfectly the first time but if you make it together with them, they are more likely to try and succeed with your support.
- If it does not work, tweak the plan until it does.
- While they are learning these skills stay close so that you can monitor and guide them through the steps they have agreed.

## 2. During a physical fight

If they are screaming, hitting, kicking, yelling, biting, or calling each other names etc. then they are already in a fight, flight or freeze state and they will not be able to think logically about solutions.

- At this point, the priority is to keep everyone safe.
- Help them to move away from one another and to calm down.
- This is not the time to solve problems.

## 3. After a fight

After they calm down ask them what they did/did not like and how they could make it better next time.

Remember to break it down into small steps and praise the effort.

Ask your children together:

- What would you like to do the same?

"I liked painting together."

"I liked painting together too."

- What would you like to change?

"Ben screaming at me."

"Lizzie painting on my page"

"I wanted to help him paint it better."

"I didn't want her to do it for me."



- So, what could you do differently next time?
- Ben what could you do instead of screaming?
- Lizzie what could you have done when you wanted to help Ben?

Create a new plan for next time.

Repeat the steps until they produce a plan that works for them.

Do not expect perfection immediately – they can learn to get better each time until it works well.

Praise their efforts at problem solving.

Support them with visuals and words that they can say.

## Consequences

Using time to calm down for both children as soon as you see them fighting physically is essential. At this point do not try to work out who is to blame. They are both in the fight and both need the space to self-regulate. Once they have calmed down their situation can be discussed. - refer to module six.

Set up consequences for hurting a sibling, damaging their property, and calling them names or saying things which are detrimental to their self-esteem. Make these clear and always follow through with the consequences.

## A balanced approach

**Each child is different, and we will love them in a unique way.**

- To prevent children resenting the attention their siblings get from their parents, ensure that you keep things as fair as possible.
- Have one-to-one time with each child.
- Focus on each child's individual strengths and do not compare them to one another.
- Give each child an individual reward chart so that they are all working towards something appropriate for them.
- Put up individual chore charts with appropriate jobs for that child's age and ability.
- Make sure that family rules are clear and that you follow through with the consequences.
- Encourage separate spaces for different activities – an older child will not always want his younger sibling with him especially they mess up their activity.
- Teach property rights – we all have property that is our own and special to us. To how many people would you lend your car or an inherited bracelet of your Mum's for example? Encourage your children to respect property and to ask permission before they use it.
- Avoid putting too much responsibility on an older/more able child – watch that you are not asking them to babysit their siblings too much or do many more chores than the younger ones.
- Give children different treats and privileges appropriate to their age.
- Give each child tasks and responsibilities that are appropriate to their age and development. Are children doing the same number of chores?